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Morality and Manoeuvring:

Codes of Honour in the Romance

Introduction

The violence in *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* is a steep contradiction against what it lauds – chivalric honour, courteous talk, courtly love, and Christian ideals – but it is seen as a necessary test of the hero's steadfastness in these principles. This steadfastness seems to hold both the plot and medieval society together, saving it from crumbling into the depravity of violence and sin. However, at the same time, upholding the virtues of civilised society instigates the tendency to turn this depravity into a spectacle.

I posit that it is this very chivalric courteousness, indulged in through games, that not only disguises, but creates a medium for actions that would be otherwise considered depraved and immoral. I discuss this premise across three sections: the role of language both within and outside the text, the notion of Christian confession and penance, and the poet's generic ambivalence, all of which betray a purposeful dismissal of morality in favour of chivalric ideals.

Covenants

In the Age of Romance, language is an indicator of one's membership in highborn company. The skills of expressing good mannerisms and propriety through speech are

highly sought after – the men of Bertilak's court even hope to "witness his graceful ways, hear the faultless phrasing of flawless speech […] and learn the merits of language" from Gawain (916 – 918). Language is therefore central to the construction of chivalric honour and courteousness as one is judged by the merit of their speech.

Accordingly, words of honour are considered oaths. A knight is bound by his word, his reputation is staked on his very actions. Indeed, when the Green Knight lays down his challenge, the only surety he asks is for Gawain to state the conditions of the pact and his name, "to tell me the truth so I can take it on trust" (380). These words are considered almost legally binding – originally, the text in medieval English used the word 'covenaunt', evoking the language of Biblical law.

The ease with which this law is laid down gives little thought to its brutality. The conventions by which the pact was arrived at are given more importance than the gruesome pact itself – an agreement to deal a death blow to another person. The alliterative style and florid language that the Gawain poet uses undermines this macabre scene further. This shift in emphasis disregards the morality of one's actions, and excuses senseless violence. The grand hunting of prey, as well, is played according to certain decrees like a game. The (then considered sinful) homosexual kisses between two men, one of whom is married, are also accepted as part of a game. What would otherwise be considered immoral is given leeway as long as it adheres to the chivalric code of honour.

This immorality is not merely permitted, but used to advantage by the characters. Most readily seen in the text, Gawain's refusal to admit to his adultery is excused because he gave his word to the lady and simultaneously upholds his oath within the rules of the game with her husband. When Lord Bertilak asks Gawain where and when he won his

kiss, Gawain asserts “That wasn't our pact […] So don't pry.” (1395). Thus, violent and immoral actions are justified and even propagated through the rules of convention.

Christian Confession

The convention of courteousness and virtue lays its foundations on honesty and integrity. The courteous man must not deceive others by going back on his word or shirking his responsibility to his lord. However, neither must he deceive others by claiming to be righteous when he is not – instead, he must bear his shame. As the poet states while praising King Arthur’s knightly qualities, it is only honourable to “accept defeat should fortune or fate smile more favorably on his foe” (98 – 99).

Transgressions of an oath, and by association of the chivalric code, too, are to be met with honesty and humility by admitting one’s shame. However, this circular reasoning – through which an offence to a set of rules is forgiven by upholding those very same rules – refuses to reckon with the moral wrong itself. As long as one reverts to chivalric code at the end, people are permitted to commit immoral deeds.

Gawain’s greatest transgression and heaviest internal conflict is keeping the girdle given to him by Lady Bertilak. By the conditions of his oath with her husband, he is bound to give him the girdle as part of his earnings of the day. Yet, he refuses to do so, out of naïve hope that the girdle will save him. However, this grave mistake that has smeared the faultless virtue of Gawain, is easily forgiven.

It is simply by “confessing your failings you are free from fault and have openly paid penance at the point of [the Green Knight’s] axe.” (2391 – 2392). Gawain, who is haunted by his mistake and foray into vice, vows to wear the girdle until he dies, as both

a punishment and reminder of his failure. King Arthur declares that “every knight in the brotherhood should bear such a belt, a bright green belt worn obliquely to the body, crosswise, like a sash, for the sake of this man” (2516 – 2519).

This tribute to Gawain extols his virtue in admitting his shame, but brushes aside any consequences for his immoral actions. This is an extension of the Christian Church’s confessional – sin is forgiven if one simply confesses to their faults and accepts the shame of their actions, there is no need to make amends. Provided that a sinner pays penance and confesses, they are freed from their immorality.

Cognizance

The Gawain poet’s self-aware romance may in fact be a condemnation of a noble society that puts more value on performative ideals of honour that have little to do with what is truly right. As Helen Cooper puts it, “the tone of gentle mockery, even of the mock-heroic, in such scenes has led to the question of whether the romance may be more of a satire or parody of the genre than a true example.”

The elevated language and light-heartedness with which scenes of violence and internal conflict are dealt with, making them into a spectacle, seem disconcerting to the reader. Moreover, the didactic presence of nature and the wild, which threatens the order of courtly life, can be read as the injunction of morality in what the poet considers to be a performative substitute of morality taking the form of a chivalric code.

The wealth of paradoxical symbols in the text – the colour green, the pentacle, the girdle – are a constant reflection of the intricate and sometimes contradictory web of courteous conventions that Gawain must navigate. However, this is a stark contrast to the

straightforward intuition that senseless violence, like beheading a man for the sake of a challenge, is morally wrong. The Gawain poet's exaggerated tone reflects the lofty chivalric code – which often seems disconnected from the ideals it claims to represent.

Conclusion

The world in the Age of Romance is governed by principles that, on the surface, stand for honesty and righteousness. However, in striving to these ideals of the chivalric code, the true morality of the actions is forgotten, and what would otherwise be considered depravity is permitted. Further, the chivalric code is used as a medium to enact needless violence, hide adultery, and shirk penance. Rather than upholding morality, chivalric honour only provides a way to stray from it. The poet may be suggesting that the system of courteousness that the people in the Age of Romance vied for – one that can be actively manipulated to allow immoral actions with little consequences – is not the norm that a society should be striving towards.

Bibliography

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